leadership of Asian nationalisms[3] in tatters and his policy of friendship towards China at all costs shown to have been a dangerous misjudgement, the shock of the defeat is said to have precipitated his death in 1964 – though not before he had been forced to jettison his much vaunted 'non-alignment', swallow his pride and beg US President John F. Kennedy for direct military intervention. Kennedy, having just stared down the nuclear abyss during the Cuban Missile Crisis, concluded that Nehru had 'lost both his nerve, and with it, his sense of reason'.[4]

Since then, the defeat – and the supine policy towards China that preceded it – has hung over his reputation. Blinded by his idealism, it is said, Nehru's miscalculations left India diplomatically isolated and militarily unprepared. In his failure to appreciate the Chinese threat, Nehru is juxtaposed with Sardar Patel, his one-time deputy who had warned him of the dangers that China posed and cautioned him against Chinese duplicity in a pointed letter in November 1950. Written shortly after the Chinese occupation of Tibet, Patel's letter has since enjoyed a long afterlife, being regularly reproduced in newspapers, quoted by columnists and celebrated for its prescience. In public discourse it is now used to graphically illustrate Nehru's strategic naivete and disregard of good counsel; and cast Patel as a rare dissenting voice against Nehru's foreign policy prescriptions, whose advice was ignored by the Prime Minister.[5]

Yet, contrary to public perception, Patel's letter was not simply a one-off, sagacious warning to Nehru.[6] It was grounded in, and the culmination of, a long-running disagreement between the two men, and indeed within the Nehru Cabinet, on the direction of India's foreign policy. As the two sets of letters reproduced here demonstrate, this was a critical debate that spanned much of 1950 and is deeply entwined with the story of Indian foreign policy. Nehru responded to Patel's famous letter with a detailed note for his Cabinet, and the resolution of this debate set the terms for Indian diplomacy for the next decade and more.